How does India look to the world today? It is among the few large economies with a robust recovery underway. We are fifth in the world, likely to be third by the end of the decade. It is a polity that, over the last decade, has shown the will to take tough decisions and embark on serious reforms. We are making big strides on human-centric development, digital public goods and green growth. India has stayed strong during the Covid storm and even gone out to help others. When its national security has been challenged, it has stood its ground firmly. Breaking from the past, it is showing zero-tolerance for terrorism. It is an India that knows how to take care of its people abroad as well. This New India shapes the global agenda and influences its outcomes. Now, it is perceived as the consensus-builder and voice of reason in a polarized world. At the same time, as the Voice of the Global South Summit demonstrated, others trust us to put forward their case. This is an India of ideas and initiatives, one that articulates the creativity and innovation of our youth.

A civilizational state is once again regaining its place in the comity of nations. It is doing so in a unique way, encouraging partnerships through its responsibilities, contributions and accomplishments. The world knows that this rise will unfold in consonance with its traditions and ethos. Obviously, its democratic values, pluralistic society and economic outlook will resonate more strongly. But they would be underpinned by deep-rooted beliefs and vast experience from a complex past and present. It is no coincidence that as policymaking is driven by those more grounded, long-standing challenges are addressed effectively. They may range from leaving no one behind to democratizing technology and promoting sustainability. Achievements, be they in space, health, start-ups or sports have instilled a new sense of pride, especially among the younger generation. And that is buttressed by a sharper awareness of heritage and the value we add to global progress.

It may be a society on the move but clearly one with a long view of its own prospects and that of the world. And it stands ready to set contemporary terms of engagement with others. Its outlook is deeply international and built around an age-old conviction of the world as one family. With each passing day, it is becoming clearer that India matters because it is Bharat.